

SHUTTERSTOCK

Starry, Starry Nights

Earlier this month, Jitendra Singh gave India's stargazers reason to rejoice. The science and technology minister announced that India will be getting its first **Dark Sky Reserve at Hanle in Ladakh**. Located in the Changthang Wildlife Sanctuary, the new optical, infra-red, and gamma-ray telescopes that will soon be added here will be in league with the world's highest. Chosen for its clear starry nights and spotless nocturnal environment, Hanle is ideally suited for watching stars—its desert surroundings keep it free of human disturbance and pollution. Locals hope new visitors will not disturb their peace.

Travelling for a Tune

UPCOMING MUSIC FESTIVALS YOU SHOULD ADD TO YOUR ITINERARIES



KAVI BHANSALI

JODHPUR RIFF, RAJASTHAN

Being held from October 6-10, Jodhpur RIFF will, as usual, spoil audiences for choice—more than 250 musicians are expected to perform this year—but it is, finally, the setting of this festival that proves breathtaking. It is often always a treat to see and hear folk music being performed at the Mehrangarh Fort, especially on nights the moon is bright and full. This year, the air in Jodhpur will not just be ringing with Manganiyar, Malwi and Khasi sounds, but also with fusions of Hebrew and Arabic music.

MAHINDRA KABIRA FESTIVAL, VARANASI, UTTAR PRADESH

You could, of course, visit Banaras at any time of year and find yourself feeling staggered. But it's in November that the weather seems kinder and the city's cultural calendar appears fuller. Held on the ghats of Banaras and scheduled to take place from November 18-20, the Mahindra Kabira Festival pays tribute to the mystic poet Kabir through music and art. This year's stellar line-up includes performances by Fouzia Dastango, sarod maestro Pandit Vikash Maharaj and The Raghu Dixit Project.



ZIRO MUSIC FESTIVAL, ARUNACHAL PRADESH

After a two-year pandemic hiatus, the Ziro Music Festival will again take place from September 29 to October 2 this year. The line-up includes veterans like Baba Sehgal and Rabbi Shergill, pop and rock acts such as Easy Wanderlings and Motherjane. But if, for some reason, the music doesn't lift your spirits, the Ziro Valley has enough lush paddy fields, gurgling rivers and views of the Himalayan range that are sure to do the trick. The valley is also home to the Apatani tribe, the ever-welcoming hosts of this festival.



SHIV AHUJA